Budget Variance Explainer

Writes the story behind a number somebody else owns.

What is Cowork?

The part of Microsoft 365 Copilot that **does the work**, not just the chatting. It reads your mail, files and meetings, then prepares the result. By default it asks you before it sends anything.

What a skill is

One file you upload once. It teaches Cowork a job you keep repeating, so you stop explaining it every time. It lives in your own OneDrive.

What this one gives you

Drafts the narrative behind a budget variance from the context the user supplies and the discussion in mail and meetings, never producing or changing the figure itself.

1. Download the file for this skill
2. In Cowork, open **Customize**
3. Go to the **Skills** tab
4. **Add** → **Upload skill**, pick the file
5. Start a **new** chat and say the words below

Then just say one of these

- *"Why are we over budget?"*
- *"Explain this variance"*
- *"What is behind the overspend?"*

What you get back

- Written commentary in your house structure
- A table of causes, with evidence and how much each explains
- The remainder that stays unexplained, stated plainly

What it will never do without asking you

- Never calculate, recalculate or forecast. Not even arithmetic on supplied figures.
- Never state a cause as certain when the evidence is circumstantial. Label it.
- Never write commentary that attributes a variance to a named individual.

THE RULE IT FOLLOWS — "Largely unexplained" is an honest and useful answer.

YOU NEED
Microsoft 365 Copilot with Cowork switched on by your admin. It is off by default.

NOT ON MOBILE
Uploaded skills only work on a laptop or desktop.

IT IS METERED
Cowork bills on usage. Your admin can cap what you spend.

MAKE IT YOURS
Open *references/config.md* to set the names and thresholds.

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